Profile: Yasser Arafat 1929–2004

1929 – Born into a middle-class Palestinian family
1948 – Fought in the first Arab–Israeli War
1949 – Studied engineering in Egypt, becoming President of Palestinian Students Union
1959 – Founded Fatah while working as an engineer in Kuwait
1969 – Became Chairman of the PLO
1974 – Addressed the UN General Assembly
1988 – Publicly recognised the state of Israel for the first time
1993 – Signed Oslo peace agreement with the Israelis
1994 – Awarded Nobel Peace Prize for his role in peace-making
1996 – Elected President of the Palestinian Authority
2004 – Died

Arafat fled to Egypt, aged 20, when the state of Israel was created and became one of a small group of young Palestinians who were students together in Cairo and who later, when working in Kuwait, formed Fatah. They dedicated themselves to the 'armed struggle' to liberate Palestine: that single aim was all-important, more so than waiting for a united Arab response which some Palestinians thought should come first.

In the 1960s Arafat was involved actively in operations against Israel and, for security reasons, he slept in a different bed every night. He was widely respected as a freedom fighter although many Israelis described him as a terrorist. The 'Battle of Karameh' (see page 80) in Jordan in 1968 was a major turning point as it brought him international recognition and a huge increase in recruits to Fatah. By 1970, about 40,000 fighters had been trained in Jordan. After 1970, when the PLO was expelled from Jordan (see page 81), most of the Palestinian armed forces were based in Lebanon.

During the siege of Beirut in 1982, when the Israeli army surrounded the largely civilian population of Beirut and bombarded it daily, Arafat toured the city endlessly, visiting the PLO frontlines, bread queues, refugee camps and hospitals.

The success of the *Intifada* in 1987–8 gave Arafat and the PLO leadership the confidence to seize the initiative and take the bold step of renouncing terrorism, recognising the state of Israel and demanding that the Israelis leave the occupied territories and agree to a Palestinian state on the West Bank and in Gaza. This alienated many of those Palestinians in refugee camps who realised that their 'right to return' to their original homes in Israel was being ignored but pleased those living in the occupied territories who had suffered over 20 years of Israeli military control.

Five years later, Arafat signed a peace deal with the Israelis and, in 1994, he stepped on to Palestinian soil, in Gaza, for the first time in 27 years. When the peace process stalled at the turn of the century, Arafat faced new challenges from groups like Hamas who rejected any deals with Israel. When Israeli troops re-entered the West Bank in 2002 they effectively surrounded Arafat in his headquarters in Ramallah. He died in 2004.